

Pastoral Letter

Oct 26/ Nov 8, 2020, Holy and Great Martyr Demetrius of Thessalonica

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To my beloved flock:

I have some essential things to say to you. This letter began when I was sitting on the porch of a cabin in Oklahoma. Getting away for a day or two gives one opportunity to think a little bit, pray, and have things resonate in one's soul. Sometimes, things are too loud for us to have an extended moment of introspection in our daily lives. I was able to do this when vacationing with my family in Broken Bow, Oklahoma. The first morning, Fr. Nicholas and I were walking on the road and speaking of pastoral things. We were talking about how there have been very great difficulties during this pandemic. Later in the day, although I was on vacation, I was feeling stressed because of all the things that had been going on and did not feel well enough to go to the park, so I stayed back with some others, took a nap, and sat in a rocking chair

and prayed and read. Then I dictated the beginnings of this letter.

I suppose someone expert in writing would say that my introduction should be expunged because it does not contain anything of the message that I want to convey to you. I would disagree. We are human beings, and we go through problems, and we must find a way to persevere. Father Nicholas and I are just like you. We have our concerns and worries, and sometimes we have good days, and sometimes we have bad days. The difficulties of the priesthood have trained me always to attack problems with aggressiveness. This aggressiveness can be prayer, fasting, or doing something I don't want to do, but I force myself to do it. I want you to be aggressive when there are

problems in your life. I don't want you to be passive about anything the troubles you. I am aggressive in this letter because I'm quite worried.

The World is getting Darker

My heart is very heavy. I am very concerned, even anxious about the future for my flock. The reason for this is because there is not enough zeal among us. The world is getting darker, and our country is becoming wrapped in chains. I'm not speaking politically here. In our political age, almost everyone thinks everything is political. I began this letter before the November election. The problems of our country and the world are not political; they are moral. Do not think that you are immune to immorality and the abyss into which our society is heading.

I don't think anything will stop this progression (certainly not an election, no matter who is elected). If we read history, we see that there have been many times when the church has been furiously persecuted. There is persecution now. It is not so much persecution of our flesh, not yet. But our minds are being oppressed, and some of you are falling prey to this persecution. We are in a secular age, with hateful and diabolical rhetoric, and hearts are cold. We are concerned about material things and the hubbub of life, and we don't think enough about spiritual things.

Local Spiritual effects & dangers of the Pandemic

When the pandemic began, there was a particular zeal, and people wanted to go to church even if they could not. We had Zoom meetings, and there was a lot of involvement by most of the parish. Since that time, it's been a very long, difficult road. For many of you, your zeal has worn

off. Our attendance at Divine Liturgy and the vigil service is smaller. We probably do not even need to have a Vespers and then a Vigil service. We can accommodate everyone in just a Vigil service, which is not attended by enough of you.

What do you think you are doing, my flock? Don't you realize that the times that you are in now are going to change? Don't you understand that the Leviathan might devour you if you do not live zealously now? Do you know what I mean by the Leviathan? I don't mean a demonic beast. I mean that your heart will be cold, and the world will influence you. And the world will be telling you that you can be a Christian as long as you don't act like one or don't believe like one and you make concessions to the world. Are you ready for this?

Are you asleep? I've told friends recently that I'm not "woke," and the reason is that since I have become a Christian, I have never been asleep! As an Orthodox Christian and even though I am a sinner, but also as a priest, how can I be sleeping if I serve the Holy Mysteries before the altar and if I pray for each of you every day?

Do you pray for one another every day? I think we know the answer to this question. Many of you do not pray very much, if at all, and many of you do not read the scriptures very much, if at all, and many of you go to the church haphazardly. And if you do come, your mind is on other things.

Do you think that you can survive the upcoming tsunami wave of unbelief and real persecution? I fear for many of you; perhaps some of you will not. I beg you as your pastor and as your spiritual father and as a sinner, a fellow sinner who needs the grace of God to warm his heart, that you

would apply yourself more to the daily life of being a Christian. There is absolutely no good reason why all of you should not try to come to the vigil and confession and the liturgy. All the things that help us meet God during the liturgy are necessary also, such as fasting, praying daily, and struggling for virtue.

I understand that some are afraid of this virus (and some of you have well-thought-out reasons for your actions), but many of you are not so fearful of the virus, but it has nonetheless caused you to become accustomed to a lower way of living. I'm concerned for you because what you are doing now is not what you will be doing in two years. The dogs of hell are getting loose. Some have already been loosed upon our country. We live in an age when there is a belief in political solutions and slogans, lifestyle choices, and sexual orientation, but not so much in God. We live in an age when, even in a country that purports to be free, there is compelled speech or compelled silence. It doesn't matter what politics you hold, people are weak, and their hearts are cold. You will see it very soon, and you will know that we are losing our freedoms.

What WILL you do? Are you ready?

What will you do when you lose your freedom? Will you give in to the secular world? I think some of you will.

When the Bolsheviks persecuted the Christians of Russia, the majority of them “got along.” There were many martyrs, in the millions and even perhaps tens of millions, but the majority “got along.” Is that what you want to do? You will have significant decisions to make in the future

regarding your employment, your worship, and your daily life. If you do not make your decisions now and aggressively live according to them, when the time comes, your choices will be made out of your personal weakness, and choices made out of personal weakness are never pleasing to God.

I speak to many of you in confession, and I ask, “How do you pray?” and “Do you read the Bible?”. The answers are almost always very disappointing. You have freedom right now to pray, read the Bible, come to worship services, and even, in most places, to live absolutely according to your conscience. If you are not using these freedoms, then your soul is not free, no matter what the appearances.

You drink water every day, don't you? You have two or three meals a day, and even snacks, don't you? You make sure that you get enough sleep, don't you? You take care of your body, and you have the latest phone, and you have good Internet at your house and clean clothes without any tears in them.

What are you doing with your soul? Is it refreshed with the water of the Holy Spirit? Does it have enough food that does not perish? Is it awake or asleep? Are you providing for it more than you provide for the needs of your body?

I have looked out during many vigils, and I have been very sad because I have seen so few of you. You might be able to get away with that if life goes on like it's been. But life will not be as it is now. Things will change.

Are you ready? I don't know if I am ready. And of course, my liturgical life and prayer life, even though I am a sinner, is bigger than most of

yours! I pray for you every day, and of course, I celebrate liturgy usually two times a week. And we have the vigil service and other services, and I'm not sure if I'm going to be ready.

The persecution will be fierce, and I am afraid for my children and my grandchildren. Am I ready to go to prison? Am I prepared to be deprived of food or shelter? Will I stand fast when the secular state tries to influence how I act as a pastor and as a Christian? During this pandemic, we have seen that the secular state in many places believes it can completely control whether services are served. What will I do if Christian services are outlawed? Whatever the pretense for them being made illegal, what will I do? Outlawing Christian services and assembly and even outlawing Christian thought has happened many times in the past. Do not think that we are immune to such persecutions.

I cannot tell you absolutely what my answer to these questions will be (how can anyone know how they will do in the test until they are tested?), but I can tell you how we must prepare to answer those questions in a way that saves our souls.

Many of you are not doing those things. May God bless you, and may God help you. Know that Fr. Nicholas and I, although we are just poor men, pray for you every day, and God hears those prayers. But if you don't pray and don't work on your virtues, then you will be drowned when the wave comes.

May God preserve and help you, and may God help you listen to this letter and hear it in the spirit in which it was written.

Things we all must change.

Here are some of the things that I want you to change.

Daily Prayer Rule

You must have a daily prayer rule! If you don't have a daily prayer rule that you are following to some degree, you are starving yourself. *You are literally committing suicide.* Are you suicidal? You might say, "No, I am not suicidal! How dare you accuse me!", but if you have life (that is, prayer, and the services and the struggle for virtue) before you and turn away from it, what else can that be called except suicide? I understand we have weaknesses, and sometimes miss our prayers, and that we get distracted. But if you don't have a rule that you are attempting to follow (and, preferably, telling Fr. Nicholas or me about it to hold you accountable and help you), you are turning away from life.

You must commit to a daily prayer rule.

This daily prayer rule must include praying for many people who have crossed your path in your life. It should *not* be a very short list. And it should not be, as children will pray, where they only say, "Lord have mercy on my mommy and daddy and everyone!". We are not children! We should be those who put away childish things. We must pray for others.

Read the Psalter!

I also highly recommend the Psalter. Why do I recommend the Psalter? It is the way the church prays. It is hard to understand. I've read it for many years, and there are still phrases in there that I don't fully understand, but there is

something in those phrases that is holy and that starts to permeate into my wretched soul and put light where there was formerly darkness. Read the Psalter! And if you have other prayers that you love, read those as well.

Perhaps you do not follow your prayer rule well. I don't care! All I care about is that you have a prayer rule that you **attempt** to follow. If you are doing this, then you will be able to follow it eventually. Please talk to Fr. Nicholas or me about developing a prayer rule. I expect every single one of you will come to speak to one of us.

Read the Scriptures!

You must be reading the scriptures. I recommend that you read the Gospels. You can read other scriptures that are edifying. I am regularly reading the Psalter (every day!), Gospels, the Epistles, and the Old Testament wisdom books, and sometimes other books. You must be doing this! You must be gathering wisdom from the Word of God because the world is trying to impart to you its wisdom, and that is the wisdom of demons. Do not think yourself to be immune to this wisdom, even if you *think* you are rejecting it! This anti-truth, anti-Christ wisdom permeates our media and entertainment, politics, schools, businesses - almost everything, everywhere.

Increase attendance in the Services

The third thing that I beg you to do is to attend the services with more care. When I became an Orthodox Christian, it was as if I was a man who had been in the desert and without a drink for many days and finally had cool, clear water. I loved the services from the very beginning, and I always have. For many of you, the services

are difficult. You get bored, and your feet hurt, and you have other things that you'd rather be doing. You might tell yourself that you barely pray during services anyway, so what is the use? You must train yourself to love the services! You will not learn this by staying home on a Saturday night and grilling or watching a television program or going to a movie or just doing whatever you do. I expect all of you to prioritize coming to the services, and if you don't, you are like that man who sees life and turns away from it: a suicidal person. I understand that there are times when you cannot come to the services, but if you do not want to go to them or if you miss them for reasons that are foolish and transitory, you are making your soul sick.

What are you to do if they bore you, or you cannot pay attention well, or you feel the stress of other things in your life and do not feel that you have the time? Do you like to do your taxes? I'm sure you do them. Perhaps you're late on them, but you do get them done because paying taxes is required of you as a citizen. You are a citizen of the Kingdom of Heaven. Some requirements are incumbent upon you because you are a citizen. And one of those requirements is to come to the services according to your ability (and be very honest about whether you can come!).

You are of the Royal Priesthood! Act like a priest!

I will tell you something that I learned many years ago. I'll be honest with you; nobody ever told me this.

For some reason, although I am a sinner, this was a kind of revelation given to me; it was something that I was very sure of right after my baptism. Do you know that you are a "holy

priesthood"? Yes, we have priests and deacons and bishops, and those who are not of those offices cannot do the things that God has ordained for the clergy to do, but *we are all of the royal priesthood*. God demands your presence in the liturgy and all of the services because you are a priest! A priest intercedes on behalf of the people to God, and God helps the people. Even if there are only one or two people in the service and you become the third person, you have caused God to give a great blessing to His people. You have interceded for God's people, and God hears that intercession, even just by your presence in the services and your attempt to pray.

Your life is not your own!

I am begging you to listen to what I am telling you and to start developing in your heart an absolute conviction that your life is not your own! You are bought with a price! You belong to God, and you are His slave. Your love for others should also make you a slave to love. Even if you don't understand it, and it does not resonate in your heart, prayer is what moves God for His people. Therefore, you must do everything you can. If you fast poorly, at least you can try to fast! If you cannot pray with great attention, at least you can stand in prayer! If you are not good at a prayer rule or have certain sins in your life, you can at least come to the services.

You are not an island! Your life is not your own! Your life belongs to your family and your parish and to anyone who crosses your path. Therefore, I am begging you that you would start

coming to the services. I would be happy to serve a vigil at the hall and a vigil at the church if 80 people want to pray at the vigil. Now we don't even have 40. God may judge us for this.

Struggle aggressively in everything!

I want you to work on a fourth thing. I mention it last; however, one could consider it the first prerequisite to all spiritual exercises because it is the energy behind everything spiritual. ***If we have a strong, intense, and aggressive intention to struggle***, we will pray, fast, attend the services, and read the Scripture.

Suppose something is very difficult for you. It could be a difficulty in your life, a frequently recurring sin, depression, sadness, sickness, or anything that upsets your soul. You must start to struggle against it. You must not just give in to it. You must aggressively work against your sins. Are you going to do that, or are you going to live a worldly life? Are you going to live like the grasshopper who thinks it is summertime all the time? When the winter came, the grasshopper starved.

May God help us. Please pray for me and remember that I pray for you. God bless you.

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